the most powerful and managed to defeat his rivals after several civil wars and rebellions.

The British, naturally, welcomed this development, as peace on the Bhutanese border was not their only concern. According to a US government study, the British also wanted to offset potential Russian advances in Lhasa and open trade relations with Tibet. 'Ugyen Wangchuk saw the opportunity to assist the British and in 1903–4 volunteered to accompany a British mission to Lhasa as a mediator.'[19] That mission, of course, was Francis Younghusband's military expedition to Tibet, and for his services in securing the 1904 Anglo-Tibetan Convention, Ugyen Wangchuk was knighted by the British. The penlop of Tongsa became a knight commander of the Indian Empire at a ceremony at Punakha dzong in 1905 attended, apart from local dignitaries, by John Claude White, the political officer of Sikkim.

Ugyen Wangchuk emerged as the most powerful man in Bhutan. The penlop of Paro was removed and replaced by a relative, a member of the likewise pro-British Dorji family. The time had come for Bhutan to be a modern state, and when the then reincarnation of the shabdrung died in 1903 and a new one had not appeared by 1906, Ugyen Wangchuk assumed total control of the country. Although a new, nominal shabdrung was found, or rather two, one for his mind and the other for his body,[20] an assembly of leading monks, government officials, and heads of the country's most important clans and families elected Ugyen Wangchuk to the position of the first *druk gyalpo*, or Thunder Dragon King, of Bhutan. The fifty-seventh and last *druk desi*, or *deb raja* as he was also called, was forced to retire, and a hereditary, absolute monarchy succeeded the old theocracy. The Dorji family became hereditary holders of the position of *gongzim*, or chief chamberlain.[21]

This new system suited the British perfectly. Ugyen Wangchuk had visited Kolkata in 1906, where he met the prince of Wales. The two men met again in Delhi in 1911, when the prince had become King George V and Ugyen Wangchuk the king of Bhutan. This was a year after the signing of the new Anglo-Bhutanese Treaty, which had placed Bhutan's foreign relations under the control of the British Government of India while granting Bhutan internal autonomy.[22]